

Whether or if?

Whether does not mean the same thing as *if*. *Whether* is used in sentences where there are two or more alternatives, while *if* can only be used when there are no alternatives.

She couldn't decide **whether** to run **or** hide.

She doesn't know **if** anything will happen.

Its or it's?

Use the possessive determiner *its* when describing a thing that belongs to something, and the contraction *it's* to represent *it is*.



It's back!



its back

Could have or could of?

In speech, the contracted form of *could have*, *could've*, is often mistakenly interpreted as *could of*. *Could of* is wrong and should never be used.

You could have told me!

Fewer or less?

Fewer is used for things that can be counted, while *less* is used for hypothetical quantities—things that cannot be counted.

I got **fewer** than ten birthday presents this year.

I have **less** work to do than he has.

Bring or take?

If an object is being moved toward the subject, the verb *bring* should be used. If it is being moved away, the verb *take* should be used.

Should I **bring** a book to read?

You can **take** one of my books.

Good or well?

Good is an adjective, so it is used to describe nouns. *Well* is mostly used as an adverb to describe verbs, adjectives, or other adverbs. However, it can also be used as an adjective to mean “healthy.” *Good* does not mean “healthy,” so it shouldn't be used in that sense.

A good chef eats well, so stays well.

↖ This adjective is describing the noun *chef*.

↖ This adverb is describing the verb *eats*.

↖ This adjective means “healthy.” ↗

Literally

Literally means “actually” or “in a real sense.” It should only be used to describe things exactly as they happened. Anything else is figurative, not literal.

I literally erupted with laughter!

